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AN AREA OF DARKNESS

A four-year wait for a car, no kissing on screen and no drinking without a permit. In the third decade of freedom, India was a land of scarcity, prohibitions and controls.

The Sixties in the West were a decade of revolution, mini skirts and the Beatles. In India it was a decade when you were constantly told what you could not do and, when for a while, it seemed the very idea of India might not work.

The decade began promisingly with seemingly impossible dreams fulfilled. In August 1960, K. Asif finally released *Mughal-e-Azam*, 15 years after he had started making the movie. A year later, the Indian Army marched into Goa and ejected the Portuguese. For the first time in four hundred years India was free from foreign colonial domination. The country was pictured as an aeroplane poised for economic take-off. Not without significance, 1961 saw the launch of two of India's leading financial dailies, *The Economic Times* and *The Financial Express*.

But soon Plane India stalled so badly on the runway that for a time there were real fears it would collapse—certainly foreign critics wrote it off—and while Armageddon was avoided, the decade ended with much of the high hopes of freedom turned to dust. For me, a *Midnight's Child*, this mood change crystallised on the night of January 26, 1963.

I grew up in Flora Fountain in the heart of Bombay (as it was then called) and the night of January 26 was always special. That night the major buildings in Bombay would be illuminated. Our house was surrounded by some historic buildings of the city and every January 26 saw thousands from Bombay's suburbs driving past our flat in open-top lorries to gaze at the illuminations. As they did so they would wave to us shouting, "*Bharat zindabad*". But on the night of January 26, 1963, there

were no illuminations, no lorries, no crowds, just deafening silence. I remember sitting by the window of our flat that night and as I looked at the statue of Flora, I got the feeling she was shedding silent tears for Bharat Mata.

Three months earlier, in October 1962, the Chinese had crushed the Indian Army in the North East Frontier Area (NEFA). For a time it seemed all of eastern India would be lost. Jawaharlal Nehru, in a radio broadcast, very nearly bid Assam goodbye and we were told how shopkeepers in Calcutta were learning Chinese. The Chinese attack on India was so overwhelming that the Cuban missile crisis, which nearly led to a nuclear war between the US and the Soviet Union, hardly made an impression on us.

Republic Day was no longer a day of celebration and the shockwaves of that invasion were felt for the rest of the decade. Not least by us students. The talk of the day was to get the country better prepared militarily and so students were told that they would not be allowed to sit for their graduation examinations unless they underwent three years' compulsory training in the National Cadet Corps. Eighteen months after the Chinese invasion, we found ourselves being given basic military training. Twice a week we gathered at a maidan near our college to be shouted at by fierce-looking Indian soldiers. I doubt if the Chinese spies lurking in the maidans were much frightened by this budding Indian army. I can recall nothing of military value I learnt, which included a spell in an NCC camp, except that it made me realise that the brave jawans we were asked to hero worship grew up to become foul-mouthed old soldiers

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